



Victorian engraving of papyrus growing by the Nile River in Egypt

A PLANT FOR PAPER

Papyrus is a giant reed that grows up to 9 ft (3 m) high. The ancient Egyptians discovered that the pith in the middle of its stems could be used to make a material for writing on—the very first paper.



AMAZONIAN GIANT

The floating leaves of the Amazonian water lily can reach a diameter of more than 6 ft (2 m).



Water lily

FLOATING ON THE SURFACE

When young, the leaves of water lilies are rolled up under water like short tubes. In the spring, the leaves reach the surface, where they open out and lie flat to form pads. In some ponds and lakes, water lilies and other plants with floating leaves can completely cover the water's surface, robbing submerged plants of the light they need to survive. The leaves are tough and leathery, so water easily runs off their surface.



Tough, waxy surface repels water

Flowers bloom above the water

Flexible stalks attach the leaves to the roots, which are anchored in the muddy bottom